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Transcripción de audio

IELTS Academic · Set 7

01 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 1: Inscripción en un curso nocturno

Registrar: Good evening, Riverside Adult Education Centre. You're speaking to Martin. How can I help you?

Student: Hello. I'd like to enrol in an evening course for the autumn term, but I have a couple of questions before I choose one.

Registrar: Certainly. The term begins in the second week of September, and most classes start at half past six. If you tell me what you're interested in, I can check the timetable and whether there are places.

Student: I work until five thirty, so that start time should be fine. I was looking at the creative courses on your website.

Registrar: Good. We still have spaces in cookery, drawing and photography. The pottery class is already full, although I can add people to its waiting list.

Student: No, those first three are the ones I was considering.

Registrar: Before we discuss them, I'll open an enquiry form. Could I take your name?

Student: Yes, my first name's Helen.

Registrar: Thank you, Helen. And your surname?

Student: It's Whitcombe.

Registrar: Could you spell that for me? I don't want to confuse it with the similar name already on my screen.

Student: Certainly - it's W-H-I-T-C-O-M-B-E.

Registrar: Whitcombe, got it. And a contact number, in case a class is cancelled or the room changes?

Student: My mobile is 07700 900318.

Registrar: Let me read that back slowly - 07700 900318.

Student: That's right. Please use that number rather than my work phone. I can receive text messages during the day, even when I can't answer a call.

Registrar: I'll mark text as your preferred contact method. May I also ask how you heard about the centre? We have been advertising in several places.

Student: A friend recommended the centre after taking a language class here. However, I first found the autumn programme when I saw your poster in the library, so put the library on the form.

Registrar: The library, thank you. We also put leaflets in the sports centre, but the poster campaign seems to be working best. Now, which course would you like to take?

Student: I was originally thinking of cookery because I enjoy it at home. Drawing also sounded relaxing. But after reading the course descriptions, I've made up my mind: I'd like to do photography.

Registrar: Photography is a popular choice. The class covers composition, lighting and basic editing. Is there a particular reason you've chosen it? Some people enrol for a hobby, while others want a formal qualification.

Student: I don't need a qualification. Mainly I'm hoping it will help with my career. I work in marketing, and lately I've been expected to take better images for our website instead of always hiring a photographer.

Registrar: That makes sense. The tutor uses practical assignments, so you should be able to apply the skills at work. One important requirement is that students bring their own camera. The centre has computers for editing, but it doesn't lend photographic equipment.

Student: That's no problem. I already have a camera with manual controls. Do I need to buy special editing software as well?

Registrar: No. The classroom computers have the software installed, and you can use them without an additional charge. A tripod is useful later in the term, but the tutor can lend those during class.

Student: Good. Could you explain the difference between the beginners' and advanced courses? I have taken holiday photographs for years, but I've never had lessons.

Registrar: In that case, start with beginners. It runs on Tuesday evenings from six thirty until eight thirty and lasts for 10 weeks. There is a short break halfway through the evening. The term fee is £120, which includes printing materials, and the class meets in Room B4 on the ground floor.

Student: Tuesday is convenient. I saw a figure of one hundred and forty pounds online. Has the price changed?

Registrar: That higher figure is for the weekend intensive course. The Tuesday evening course is definitely £120. You can pay the full amount today or reserve a place with a small deposit.

Student: And is there something more advanced afterwards if I want to continue?

Registrar: Yes. The follow-up course concentrates on portrait and low-light work. It runs on Thursday evenings. It's slightly shorter, at eight weeks, and its fee is lower too: £95. That class is upstairs in Room B7, but you cannot join it until you have completed the beginners' course or shown the tutor a portfolio.

Student: Thursday would actually be difficult this term, so the beginners' class is the right one. I'll pay a deposit now and the balance before the first lesson.

Registrar: Fine. The deposit is refundable until seven days before the course begins. I'll print your enrolment form and email a list of what to bring. Please arrive ten minutes early on the first Tuesday so the tutor can check everyone's equipment.

Student: I will. Thank you for taking the time to explain everything.

Registrar: You're welcome, Helen. Your place is reserved as soon as I process the deposit.

02 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 2: Audioguía del museo

Welcome to the Harborough Maritime Museum. This audio tour will introduce the building and the main displays, then leave you free to explore in more detail. The complete route takes about forty-five minutes, although you can pause the guide at any point. Before we begin, here are a few practical details. Admission to the main galleries is completely free for every visitor; you do not need to collect a ticket for them. Our children's activity trail is free as well. Families can pick up a trail sheet and pencil at reception, and there is no charge for returning visitors who want a second sheet. Other activities are priced separately. The guided harbour tour costs six pounds, the temporary exhibition on the top floor requires a three-pound ticket, and hiring this audio guide also carries a small charge.

Those three items are sometimes included in special group bookings, but they are not free to the general public. The museum opens at ten each morning. From Monday to Saturday it closes at five thirty; on Sundays it closes an hour earlier. Photography is allowed in most rooms, provided you do not use flash. Please look for the camera symbol beside each doorway, because a few borrowed objects cannot be photographed. Now, take a moment to look at the building around you. The museum occupies a nineteenth-century warehouse which once stored timber, rope and other goods arriving by sea. It was not originally a customs house, as many visitors assume. Local merchants built it beside the working quay so cargo could be moved indoors quickly during bad weather.

Much of the brickwork and the heavy wooden roof are original. We begin in the entrance hall. In the glass case ahead is the oldest object in the collection: a ship's bell made roughly four hundred years ago. Divers recovered it from a wreck just off this coast. The vessel's name cannot be read clearly, although researchers think it traded between Britain and northern Europe. Beside the case, you can hear a recording of the sound made by a modern copy; the original bell is too fragile to ring. Next, go through the wide doorway on your left. The first gallery contains detailed models of fishing boats. Local craftsmen built them over the past century, often copying vessels on which they had worked. Some visitors expect full-sized boats here, but the ceiling is too low, so the museum displays those outside during summer. Notice how the models change from sail to engine power as you move clockwise around the room. Continue into the map gallery. Its charts show how the coastline near Harborough has changed over several centuries as the sea advanced, retreated and deposited sand. An interactive screen lets you compare the present shore with surveys from 1750 and 1900. The display is about the shape of the coast, rather than shipping routes, although an old navigation chart hangs near the exit. When you reach the stairs, follow the blue signs to the upper floor. Our most popular exhibit is there: a complete Victorian diving suit with a heavy brass helmet, weighted boots and an air hose.

It looks impossibly cumbersome today, yet divers used equipment of this kind for difficult work beneath ships. A modern wetsuit stands nearby for comparison, but visitor surveys consistently identify the Victorian diving suit as the favourite. In the same room, a short film tells the history of the port through photographs and interviews. It begins on the hour, every hour, and lasts twenty minutes. There is no extra charge for the film, but seats are limited, so arrive a few minutes early. A separate documentary about lifeboats plays only for school groups. After the film, you may want

refreshments. The café is at the rear of the building, beside the garden. On fine days, tables are placed among the old anchors outside.

The shop is closer to reception, while toilets and baby-changing facilities are reached from the corridor between the two. Before going upstairs, please put large bags and wet coats in the cloakroom near the entrance. This protects both the exhibits and other visitors in the narrow galleries. Small handbags may be carried, and lockers are available for valuables. Staff cannot store luggage behind the reception desk. At the end of your visit, you can rejoin the waterfront path through the garden gate or return to the main entrance. If you have questions, volunteers wearing navy badges are stationed on both floors. Enjoy your visit, and press the green button whenever you are ready to continue.

03 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 3: Diseño de un experimento de psicología

Tutor: Come in, Megan and Ryan. I read the outline you sent yesterday. You've settled on a topic for your psychology experiment, so talk me through it in your own words.

Megan: We want to test whether background music affects how well students concentrate while reading. We considered studying sleep and attention, but collecting reliable sleep data seemed too ambitious for this assignment.

Tutor: Sensible. What first led you to the music question? Was it a paper from your reading list?

Ryan: We found a useful paper afterwards, but it wasn't where the idea came from. Megan and I both revise with music on, and we kept disagreeing about our own habit. She thinks songs help her focus; I usually end up listening to the words instead of studying. We wanted to investigate that disagreement properly.

Megan: You gave us advice on narrowing the topic once we mentioned it, but the original suggestion was ours.

Tutor: Good distinction. A question that grows from observation can work well if the method is rigorous. What exactly will change between the groups? I'm asking for your independent variable.

Megan: The type of music played. One group will read in silence, one will hear instrumental music, and one will hear music with lyrics. We briefly considered testing different volumes, but we decided to keep volume constant for both music groups.

Ryan: The reading period will be twelve minutes in every condition as well. We don't want task length to vary.

Tutor: Excellent. And your dependent measure? Saying “concentration” is too broad unless you define how you will observe it.

Ryan: Immediately after reading, everyone will complete the same short comprehension test. We'll count correct answers. We thought about asking people how focused they felt, but a self-rating alone would be less dependable.

Tutor: You could collect a rating as secondary data, but the test score should remain your main measure. Now tell me about participants.

Megan: Our first idea was to test friends because they would be easy to contact. Then we realised most of them study psychology, so they might guess the purpose of the experiment.

Ryan: I suggested choosing names at random from a class list, but we aren't allowed to contact students who haven't agreed to hear about research.

Megan: So our final plan is to put up a notice on the student portal and invite volunteers. The notice will give the time commitment without revealing which kind of music we expect to work best.

Tutor: That is the appropriate recruitment route. How many volunteers are you aiming for?

Ryan: Forty-five, with fifteen in each condition. If a few people withdraw, we should still have enough for this small study.

Tutor: The proposed groups are adequate for the assignment. My main concern lies elsewhere. Your draft says each participant will complete all three conditions. By the third reading, people may be better at the procedure simply because they have practised it. That practice effect could distort the comparison.

Megan: We wondered whether the music might be too loud, but we'll calibrate it before testing and use the same level each time.

Tutor: Good, and that removes volume as the central concern. The repeated practice remains the problem.

Ryan: Then let's use different people for each condition. It means individual reading ability may vary between groups, but random allocation should spread that variation.

Tutor: Agreed. Keep a record of the allocation method. Have you arranged a pilot study yet?

Megan: We can run a small pilot later, once the materials are ready. The library room is already provisionally booked, so booking is not our immediate task.

Tutor: What must you do next, then?

Megan: First we need to write the comprehension questions. Then we'll ask two classmates who are not taking part to check that the wording is clear and that every answer is actually in the passage.

Ryan: We'll send the checked questions to you before we recruit anyone.

Tutor: Exactly. Preparing and checking that test comes next; the pilot follows after I approve it. Let's go through the remaining details so your protocol is complete. Where will testing take place?

Ryan: In a quiet room in the library. It is away from the entrance and has a sign we can put on the door, so interruptions should be rare.

Tutor: Use that same room for every participant. The equipment position and lighting should stay constant too. Now consider the reading materials.

Megan: We have selected three passages about unfamiliar historical events, so prior specialist knowledge should not help one group.

Tutor: Make sure every passage is the same length. Similar topics are useful, but a longer passage would demand more effort and introduce another variable.

Ryan: We'll match the number of words and check sentence difficulty as closely as we can.

Tutor: Good. What about the directions participants receive?

Megan: Rather than explaining the task differently each time, one of us will read the instructions aloud from a fixed script. That way each group hears exactly the same wording.

Tutor: Record any questions participants ask, but don't add extra explanations during a session. How will you present the findings?

Ryan: We'll calculate an average score for each condition. In the report, the three scores will appear in a bar graph, because the groups are separate categories rather than measurements across continuous time.

Megan: We may include the self-ratings in a small table, but the graph will show the comprehension results.

Tutor: Finally, ethics. Your information sheet explains that people may leave at any time, which is good. Before anyone takes part, however, you must obtain written consent. An email saying they are interested is not sufficient.

Ryan: The consent forms are drafted. We'll keep signed copies in the secure project folder and use participant numbers in the data file.

Tutor: Then you're making good progress. Send me the comprehension questions by Friday, and once they are checked we can review the pilot procedure.

04 Comprensión auditiva - Sección 4: La ciencia del sueño

Good afternoon. Today's lecture introduces the science of sleep, a behaviour so familiar that it is easy to underestimate its complexity. We spend roughly a third of our lives asleep. Scientists agree that sleep supports several biological processes, although no single explanation accounts for every feature of it. Rather than treating sleep as a period when the brain simply switches off, researchers now describe it as an active sequence of changing states. We will begin with the systems that regulate when we sleep. Two broad forces interact. One is sleep pressure, which generally increases the longer a person remains awake and declines during sleep. The other is timing information from an internal clock.

This interaction explains why someone can feel extremely tired late at night yet become temporarily more alert after sunrise. As darkness approaches, the brain normally increases production of a hormone called melatonin. Rising levels help us feel drowsy and signal that the biological night has begun. Melatonin does not act like a powerful sleeping drug, and taking more of it cannot compensate for every cause of poor sleep. Its central role is as a timing signal, coordinating the body's preparation for rest. That signal operates within a roughly twenty-four-hour pattern known as the circadian rhythm. The central clock is located in a small region of the brain, but clocks in other tissues respond to its timing. Left entirely without external cues, the daily cycle may drift slightly.

Exposure to daylight, especially in the morning, resets it each day and keeps it aligned with the local day-night schedule. Meal times and activity provide secondary cues, but light is the strongest one for most people. Artificial light can alter this process. Bright screens late in the evening may delay the normal rise in sleepiness, particularly if they are held close to the eyes. The effect varies among individuals and depends on brightness, duration and timing. This is why advice to reduce evening screen use is about preparing the clock for sleep, rather than claiming that any brief glance at a phone will cause a disorder. Once asleep, we move through a repeating pattern of stages. For a simple overview, these are often grouped into two main types: REM sleep and deep sleep.

REM stands for rapid eye movement. Brain activity in this stage can resemble waking activity, vivid dreaming is common, and most large muscles are temporarily less active. Deep sleep belongs to non-REM sleep and is marked by especially slow, synchronised brain waves. A night's sleep contains several cycles, and their composition changes towards morning. The stages contribute differently to restoration. Deep sleep is strongly associated with physical recovery. During it, the body repairs tissue, rebuilds muscle and releases growth hormone. Athletes therefore pay attention to sleep as part of training, but the same processes matter after ordinary daily activity.

Deep sleep tends to be more abundant in the first portion of the night, which is one reason a severely shortened night cannot be fully repaired by simply lying in later once. REM sleep is particularly important for the brain. Evidence links it to emotional processing and to consolidating memory, the process through which newly learned material becomes more stable. Other sleep stages contribute to learning too, so it would be misleading to assign all memory work to REM alone. Still, experiments in which researchers interrupt selected stages show that the architecture of sleep matters, not just the total number of hours spent in bed. We can see this in students. Reading

notes until very late may create extra study time, but reduced sleep can impair attention during the next day's test and make new learning less efficient. A regular pattern of study followed by adequate sleep generally supports recall better than an all-night session, even though the student who stayed awake spent more hours looking at the material. Now consider the effects of insufficient sleep on health. Even several nights of restricted sleep can alter the activity of immune cells and weaken the immune system. That does not mean one late night guarantees an infection. It means that repeated shortage reduces one part of the body's defence and is associated with greater vulnerability over time. There are immediate psychological effects as well. Sleep loss has a strong influence on mood.

Tired people often report greater irritability and anxiety, and they may react more strongly to minor difficulties. Attention and decision-making can also suffer. These changes matter in workplaces involving driving, machinery or medical judgement, where a brief lapse can have serious consequences. Sleep needs vary with age and from person to person. Teenagers generally need more sleep than adults, partly because adolescence is a period of rapid growth. Their internal timing also tends to shift later, so many find it difficult to fall asleep early even when school requires an early start. This biological tendency can conflict with social schedules; it should not automatically be interpreted as laziness. Adults sometimes assume that older people need almost no sleep.

In fact, sleep may become lighter and more fragmented with age, but restorative sleep remains important. Daytime naps can be useful in some circumstances, although long or late naps may make it harder for a person with night-time difficulties to settle at bedtime. Persistent difficulty sleeping deserves separate attention. The most common sleep disorder is insomnia, defined by repeated trouble falling asleep, staying asleep or obtaining restorative sleep despite having an adequate opportunity to rest. It differs from choosing to stay awake for work or entertainment. Other disorders include breathing interruptions and abnormal movements, so treatment should depend on the cause rather than on one general remedy. For healthy sleep, consistency is often more useful than a dramatic weekend correction.

Experts recommend keeping a regular bedtime and waking time, making the room dark and reasonably cool, and allowing a quiet transition from work to rest. Regular daytime activity can help, whereas vigorous exercise immediately before bed affects people differently. Diet and stimulants also matter. In particular, experts advise avoiding caffeine in the evening. It blocks signals associated with sleep pressure and can remain active in the body for many hours. Coffee is the obvious source, but tea, energy drinks, chocolate and some medicines may contain it too. Alcohol may initially make a person feel sleepy, yet it can disrupt the later structure of the night. The practical message is that good sleep depends on timing, environment and behaviour as well as duration.

In our next lecture, we will compare human sleep with the very different patterns found across the animal kingdom.